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The present collection of articles addresses the issue of the nature of language in the context of the relationship between word and image. This issue is far from being one of the many among various topics of research and academic life. It deals with the emerging understanding of the place and the nature of humanities and the way of our responding to the present challenges. The humanities, after being recognized to be in deep crisis in the twentieth century, became again vitally important at the time of unprecedented global challenges of the twenty-first century.

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BETWEEN WORD AND IMAGE IN ANCIENT EGYPTIAN RELIGIOUS TEXTS

Abstract: The article aims to track the mutual interaction between sacred texts and images in Ancient Egyptian culture. It points to the particular function of sacred texts and images and their power to create a reality of the afterlife for the deceased person. The context of the Egyptian tomb provides us both with opportunity to trace the long and well documented developments and to make comparisons between royal and elite tombs in different periods. The observations that were made leads to the conclusion that in the development of the ancient Egyptian culture the visual culture and images received a greater importance in time. In the New Kingdom written texts and images became complementary to each other. After the end of the New Kingdom highly symbolical images start to represent even abstract ideas and, and, in some cases replace the written texts. Better understanding of the relations between sacred texts and images could provide us with the key to decode these abstract images and the Ancient Egyptian concepts.

Key words: visual culture, image, religion, sacred literature of Ancient Egypt

Introduction

The well preserved monuments of Ancient Egypt with the vast number of pictorial representations constitute an abundant source for understanding this ancient culture and the way of thinking of the inhabitants of the Nile valley. Nevertheless, our knowledge of ancient Egyptian culture depends more on the study of written texts than on the study of the images. Only recently increased attention to images and visual culture starts to open the way of new discussions about the role of image in Ancient Egypt. This trend

is a reflection of some developments of the study in iconology and visual culture in the field of other humanitarian disciplines[1].

One of the key points in discussion of the role of the visual images in Ancient Egypt is the question about the interconnection and the interdependence of the script/texts and images. Recently John Baines formulated the connection of *Written culture* to *Visual culture* in a separate monograph study (Baines, 2007). Earlier the topic was discussed by Andrey Bolshakov in several articles (Bolshakov & Sushchevski, 2003; Bolshakov, 2003; Bolshakov, 2003) who observed the difference between spheres of application of these "two languages" of Ancient Egyptian culture as he called the text and the representation[2]. Speaking of images with the term of "language" as a tool to convey complex meanings and concepts immanently lead to idea of a "grammar" of images. The search and the establishment of a "grammar" of Egyptian pictorial images for the moment is a goal too far and too difficult to achieve. But in some cases as the study of the tomb complexes and the temples with their decorative program, we could try to formalize some rules which help us to "decode" these decorative programs. In these cases the relevance and interconnections between *word/texts* and *image/representations* become even more important, as the data taken from each sphere could supplement the understanding of the other.

The purpose of this study is to review the main points of functional connection between the worlds of the word and the image, religious texts and their representations, especially in the case of the funerary cult, to give insights for the understanding the changes that took place in these connections and finely to show some valuable areas for the future study.

Hieroglyphs and images

The abundance of hieroglyphic inscriptions and the vast number of pictorial representations that survived from the time of the Pharaohs are our key tools of understanding the Ancient Egyptian culture. Both – the hieroglyphic script and the system of the pictorial representations developed simultaneously at the beginning of the historical period by the end of IV mill. B. C.

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1 See Uehlinger, 2015 with the outline of contemporary research, arguing that the study of religion would benefit from shifting the scholar attention towards the images and visual culture. A detailed overview of the progress of iconographic studies in Egyptology is provided by Mueller, 2015. For the discussion of understanding the images from the methodological point of view of semiotics and hermeneutics, see Angenot, 2015.

2 From 2000 on the topic of *Word and Image* was also presented by Prof. Sergei Ignatov as a leading seminar of the Department of Mediterranean and Eastern Studies in New Bulgarian University.

The formulation of the system of pictorial representation is evident in the same time as the first hieroglyphic inscriptions were attested.

The text and the representation (the word and the image) in Egyptian culture remain complementary to each other since their first attestations till the end of Egyptian civilization and the victory of Christianity by IV c. A. D. One of the reasons for this mutual interdependence between the text and the representations is the fact that Egyptian hieroglyphs continued to represent identifiable objects in all periods of their existence.

Henry Fisher had presented the hieroglyphic system of writing long time ago in these words: "The hieroglyphic writing may be described as a series of concrete representations, some of which are phonetic in character and others ideographic, it is equally valid to consider Egyptian sculpture and painting as the equivalent of ideographic component. In painting and relief the difference is a matter of relatively greater size, with the addition of pictorial detail and a certain degree of interaction" (Fischer, 1977, p. 3).

This mutual interdependence between representation and the hieroglyphic script is clearly evident in two cases. First, representations could play the role of the determinatives in the script. In many monuments there is no determinative after the name of the owner, as he was represented in the monument side by side with his name in hieroglyphic script. Second, orientation of the hieroglyphs follows the direction of the images which they supplement. The main features of organization the hieroglyphic script in accordance with the representations, according to Fisher are: *confrontation*, *symmetry* and *concordance*.

Despite the assertion that both hieroglyphic script and Egyptian representational system develop together and that they are two sides of the same coin, the same fundamental process of cognition, scholarly attention was attracted mainly towards the script and the texts. Pictorial representations often were viewed as something given and too obvious to be analyzed. One of the first exceptions from this negligent approach toward the representation in Egyptian culture is the book of Heinrich Schaefer (Schafer, 1919), published at the end of WWI. This fundamental work solves with outstanding success, many problems in the analysis of non-perspective pictorial representations. Schaefer provides insights that lead to the new understanding of Egyptian representational art. He claims that he discovered most important implications for the study of pictorial representation as such. His study put Egyptian visual material together with the so-called 'pre-Greek' representations and compared typical features of the primitive art (traditional

art of tribal societies) with the representational system of the first civilizations. His work was praised by historian of the art outside Egyptology as E. H. Gombrich in his *Art and Illusion, A study in the psychology of pictorial representation*.

The term that was used by Schaefer is a neologism, *geradvorstellig* that was rendered in English as "based on frontal images", where "frontal" means "unaffected by foreshortening".

The term of Schaefer coined for Egyptian representational methods *geradvorstellig* (based on frontal images) was replaced by Emma Brunner-Traut[3] with the term *aspective*. The use of the term can be expended to include other manifestation of Egyptian culture as well as art. *Aspective* is a proper term to denote pre-Greek art, such as primitive (or traditional) art, or art of other ancient civilizations which differs from *perspective* art introduced for the first time by the Ancient Greeks and developed with the growth of the science in the Renaissance to true perspective, based on mathematical calculations.

Egyptian representational system of two-dimensional representations is based on the patchwork of collecting and uniting visual images of different parts of represented object into the single and harmonious form. For example the human body was represented by the head, legs and arms *en profil*, while the torso was displayed in *en face.* So, on the flat, two-dimensional surface the image was reproduced as a combination of elements viewed from the easiest to be recognized plan, no matter that they will contradict with the single determined viewpoint of the observer based on the perspective. The same attitude is apparent for the hieroglyphs – there are not only the signs for the whole human figure in different positions, but there are also signs for eyes, ears, face, legs, arms – all parts of the human body.

Although *aspective* view does not fit the *perspective* view which we are accustomed to see as "realistic", *aspective* view is actually a realistic one, because it reflects all aspects of the object represented realistically, as they are, and not as they appear to be in the eyes of the viewers.

This *aspective* approach of combining elements to constitute an image has great potential for symbolic representation of abstract ideas. Clear example for this potential of Egyptian imagery are the representations of

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[3] Emma Brunner-Traut contributes the English translation of the work of Schaefer done by J. Baines (Schaefer, 1974, pp. 421–446) with the introduction of the new term, *aspective*.

Egyptian gods, they combine essential characteristics of the god into single abstract image. The god Khepri for example is represented often by the human body (denoting the person of the god) with the head of the beetle (the hieroglyph xpr – denoting the name of the god – "to become", to develop", "to transform", etc.).

The symbolic nature of the hieroglyphs and the fact that the hieroglyphs remained representations as well, leads to a second level of understanding or reading the images. Some examples show that images could be read as hieroglyphic inscriptions due to their symbolic nature. The name of the king Ramesses II could be read symbolically represented in his sculpture[4], or the name of Ramesses III in Medinet Habu temple[5] (Radwan, 1975, p. 228; Spiecer, 2000, p. 348), represented by the similar images in relief, or the full list of epithets of the royal name of Ramesses VI represented in his tomb in a symbolic way by the rows of different gods (Piankoff, 1954, pp. 63–70; Werning, 2008, p. 126; Taterka, 2012, p. 446).

In three dimensional representations ancient Egyptians achieved very high level of realism, especially for the faces of their sculpture. This achievement is due to the idea that three dimensional representation of the deceased person was considered as his eternal body replacement of actual physical body. Rituals were performed over the new sculptured body to make it alive. The ritual of the *Opening of the mouth* was most important for reaching this goal.

The Old Kingdom tombs of kings and the elite – between the texts and the images

During the Old Kingdom, representations in the chapel of the tombs of the elite became powerful vehicle of the creation of whole world of the deceased (Bolshakov, 1986; Bolshakov, 1987). These images represent various aspects of daily life – full display of the activities in the domain of the person, his pr-Dt. There are representations of seeding the crops, harvesting, threshing the collected crops with the use of donkeys, transporting the grain to the granaries, grinding the flour and backing the breads. The same are the representations of the process of making beer, butchering the meat, hunting and fishing... Finally the breads together with a long list of products, meat, vegetables, sweet oil and clothes are presented before the master of

4 So the famous statue of the king from Tanis now in the Cairo Museum JE № 64. 735 – Spieser 2000, 258, Nr. 228 and p. 348.

5 Medinet Habu VIII, Pl. 643.

the tomb, sitting in front of an offering table. The owner of the tomb is depicted watching these agricultural scenes, or controlling the process of work, enjoying the display of wealth before his eyes. We could say that all these images are realistic attempt to portray visible reality. There are no fantastic images, gods, spirits, or celestial realms. The visible reality, and themes connected with the cult of the deceased are predominant. Internal dynamic of the representations is achieved by the organization of the images and their orientation. The image of the owner is repeated many times in the scenes, oriented towards the entrance of the chapel, and the procession of people who brought the goods in the altars of the tomb are oriented "moving" to the focal point of the tomb – the False door, usually in the west. Through this repetition of the images ancient artists express movement in the tomb. Both worlds – of the living and of the dead are mingled in this eternal movement – living are coming in to the internal part of the chapel and its offering tables, and at the same time the owner is going out from the door of the chapel.

The texts in the chapel supplement the world of pictorial representations. They state what is represented, usually using the infinitive form for the action represented, they denote the terms such as social group of people involved in the action, the words for their objects, instruments, goods, etc. In this respect the text has additional value to the image. Most common texts in the chapels of the tombs are offering formulas such as Htp-dj-njswt. So the chapel was provided not only with the representations of the offerings, but also with the magical words that express the same idea. In some cases the additional texts are direct speech of the people represented. The written speech and the conversation of the people could give us feeling of their emotional state and motivation. This technique makes the images extremely vivid and alive. Thus the text contributes to the power of the image.

The written texts in the chapels of the Old Kingdom point to a different kind of information about the owner of the tomb. These texts are auto/biographical texts, appeals to the living who will eventually visit the tomb or contracts with the priests or workers that documenting the rights of the owner who paid for the construction of his tomb or its funeral service. So different kind of information was put into images or texts, and the combination of both means of expression – text and image – makes the funeral complex a powerful tool for achieving the immortality of the owner of the tomb.

Despite the abundance of pictorial representations and texts, there are no written *sacred texts* in chapel of the tomb. There are only some representations of the lector-priests, so-called Hrj-Hb, who are reading liturgical texts

from the papyrus which they bear. This is a testimony that sacred texts are used in the rituals performed in the tomb (the funerary ritual, the offering ritual etc.), but in the same they were not recorded on the wall of the chapels due to their sacred nature.

As the chapel is designed for the living (relatives and mortuary priests) who will visit the tomb and bring offerings, who will recollect the images of the deceased, pronounce his name, and keep his name and memory alive, so the underground part of the tomb is designed to preserve the body of the deceased. This part of the tomb once constructed remains inaccessible to the visitors and living. By the end of the Vth dynasty, the world of representations penetrates the burial chambers of the private tombs, and the first images were put on the walls of the sarcophagus chamber. At the same time the sacred texts were written in the underground chambers of the pyramids of the kings. These texts appeared with the reign of the king Unas at the end of the Vth Dynasty. They are inscribed at the Burial chamber and at the Antechamber of his pyramid at Saqqara. The king's of VIth Dynasty also have in the subterranean parts of their pyramid complexes Pyramid texts. These texts are real treasure for the study of Ancient Egyptian religion, and not only. They are the oldest attested religious texts in the history of humanity. These texts are magical, and most of them are designed to transform the dead king into an Akh (commonly translated as "Spirit"), and to convey his immortal spiritual powers into the orbit of the eternal recreation of the Sun.

Important feature of the representational form of the hieroglyphs in Pyramid texts is the fact that they are treated as alive. So, some signs of animals, snakes, human beings, considered as dangerous for the corpse of the deceased are represented mutilated – pictures of men are without legs, the body of lying lion is cut into two pieces, the sign of the fish, used to write the word for the corpse – XAt is avoided in writing, as the fish could be rotted and the purity of the sacred space would be polluted (see the last Gundacker, 2016, p. 239). The fear from the potential tread of the image is obvious. The fear was eventually overcome in the next generations, and the Pyramid texts expand not only in the burial chamber, but also in the antechamber, and corridors leading to it, receiving greater and greater space in the underground parts of the royal tomb.

In the time of the Middle Kingdom the sacred texts continue to be written in close proximity to the body – this time on the inside walls of the wooden coffins. They formed a new corpus of texts, known as the Coffin texts. Part of the same corpus is so-called Book of the Two ways, a map of the Beyond

supplemented with proper magical spells, reproduced on the floor of the coffin. Here for the first time we could see the images of demons and celestial beings. The figures are clumsy and schematic – this is the first known attempt to reproduce *invisible* reality in the Egyptian art. In the upper registers of the internal sides of the coffins there are also representations of ritual objects and offerings, the so-called *friese d' objets*, here once again the world of the text and the world of representation are in mutual interaction.

The New Kingdom sacred texts and the new repertoire of images

The true potential of representations in religious contexts starts to be evident in the time of the New Kingdom. Funerary texts as the Book of the Dead written on papyrus superseded the texts on the walls of the coffins from the earlier period. The Book of the Dead is a collection of spells (up to approximately 200), arranged in a different order which follows certain rules that are not so evident to the modern readers. The text of the spell is supplemented in some instances by the picture, vignette. The vignette contains the image of some importance for the main theme of the spell. At the beginning the vignettes were only few, but by the middle of the XIXth Dynasty they become an integral part of the book, produced with the great care and with the artistic mastership. The owner of the funeral papyrus was represented in these vignettes more often and repeatedly. The book become like a pictorial narrative for the journey of the dead in the realm of the gods and his transformation into eternal being. It was no longer only a collection of magical spells. The Book of the Dead was inscribed also in the private tombs of the ruling elite, especially in Theban area. Its attestation in the tombs begins with the reign of Thutmose IV. Gradually the Book of Dead and religious scenes, representing the deceased before gods of the Netherworld become predominant iconographic motifs in the tomb decoration, replacing the old iconographic themes such as scenes of daily life, agricultural activities etc. In other words the images of the visible reality were replaced by the images of invisible reality of the world beyond. In this development the role of the image took more important role than the sacred texts. In many cases the chapters (spells) from the Book of the Dead were represented only by the vignettes, sometimes supplemented by titles of the spells, without the entire hieroglyphic text. So, the image replaces the texts in their role to be magical tool helping the dead person in his afterlife.

In the sarcophagus chamber of the royal tomb from the beginning of the XVIIIth Dynasty were written the Book of Amduat or The texts from the Secret Chamber and the Litany of Re. The first composition is a magical plan of the nocturnal voyage of the Sun-god in the Netherworld. The Litany

of Re contains hymns to the Sun-god that enabled the king to transform himself or his Ba (Soul) into the Ba (soul) of the Sun-god. So, both compositions are designed to achieve one purpose – immortality of the king. Amduat is a magical map of transformation of the sun and its movement in the night, while the Litany of Re is a guarantee that the king will join the Sun in this eternal circuit. By the beginning of the next XIXth Dynasty and in the XXth Dynasty on the walls of king's tombs appeared other sacred composition such as The Book of the Gates, The Book of the Caverns, The Book of the Earth, The Book of the Cow, and others.

The nightly journey of the Sun-god is the main focus of all the Books of the Netherworld. This process has many dimensions: it is a voyage into the space of the universe, when the Sun circuits in the two hemispheres of the world – visible and invisible; it is also a mechanism of renewal and rebirth, where the powers of death and life meet each other to produce new beginning; it is also descending of the Sun's Ba (Soul) into the darkness of his Corpse (Body); it is a model for uniting the human soul with his corpse and to produce new form of his life, or, in other words it is a journey into the space of the human consciousness. The Ba is linked with the upper hemisphere – the heaven, while the Body is linked with the lower hemisphere, called Duat in Egyptian. According to Beatte George (George, 1972) the nocturnal journey of the Sun represents the idea of identity of the *macrocosmos* (the model of the world) and the *microcosmos* (the image of the human being). And A. Niwinski called this journey "*spiritus movens* of the whole life in the nature" (Niwinski, 1987–1988).

The main characteristic of all the royal books is the presence of abundant images of gods, demons and mysterious beings. They were pictorial representations of the afterlife accompanied by the texts in which the power of the image took greater part than the text itself. Here the images and the sacred texts are in close interaction with each other. The images convey the ideas in texts using their own pictorial language. Let us see some examples denoting the power of the images in these books.

In the Book of Amduat (The Book of what is in Duat (Underworld)), the Ba of the Sun-god descends into the deep of the Netherworld and units with his Corpse. Here, Re is Ba and Osiris is his Corpse. The word "corpse" (XAt) in Egyptian is feminine, while the word Ba is masculine (Hornung, 1963–1967, I, pp. 106, 4; ibid. pp. 110, 9). The body of Re is also the body of Osiris (Hornung, 1963–1967, I, pp. 38, 2; George, 1972, 17 n. 7; Hornung 1963–1967, II, p. 124; Hornung, 1982, p. 95, 111). The word Ba could be written by the sign of the Ba-bird (jabiru), or in some cases by the sign of the

ram. So, the Head of the Sun-god in Underworld books is usually depicted as ram-head to represent that this is actually the Ba of the Sun. This form became the typical image of the Night sun. The image of the ram-headed god is described in Amduat as the "flesh", literally the "meat" of the Sun. When the sun comes out of the Underworld his flesh assumes a new form of the visible sun, the sun-disk.

But the most clearest representations of the union of Re with Osiris is an illustration to the text of the Book of the Dead, Spell 182[6]. This image comes from the tomb of the queen Nofertari (Piankoff, 1954, p. 34, fig. 5; Hornung, 1976, p. 60; Hornung, 1982, p. 94) in the Valley of the Queens. Similar representations are attested in some tombs of Deir el-Medina[7].

The body contains the typical features of the both gods. The mummified and wrapped body is that of Osiris, and the ram-head with the sun-disk belongs to Re. The fusion of the two gods is reflected in the similar texts of the Book of the Dead. In the Spell 181 it is stated that Osiris takes possession of Re's attributes[8]. In an invocation to Osiris we read: itn. f itn. k stwt. f stwt. k wrt. f wrt. k aA. f aA. k xaw. f xaw. k nfrw. f nfrw. k ...

"His disk (of Re) is your disk (of Osiris), his rays are yours rays, his Crown is yours Crown, his greatness is your greatness, his appearing is your appearing, his beauty is your beauty..."

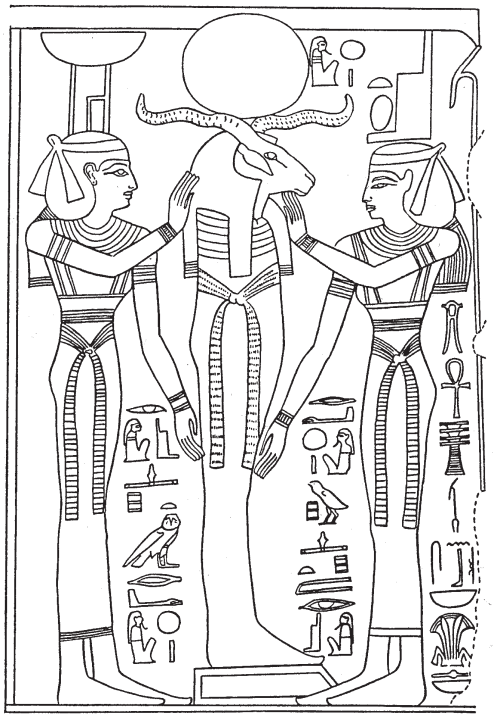


Fig 1. The union of Re and Osiris.

6 Book of Dead, Spell 182 = Naville 1886, CCVII, 6.

7 TT 335 (Photo – Derchain 1965, 157, fig. F), TT 336 and TT 290, where the inscription is situated to the sun-disk between two sycamores – Hornung 1982, 95, n. 113.

8 Book of Dead, Spell 181 = Naville 1886, CCV, 7–9.

The inscription around the representation of the join figure of Re-Osiris reads: "It is Re who rests in Osiris. It is Osiris who rests in Re."

This inscription is a quoting from the royal composition The Litany of Re. The title of the Spell 182 from the Book of the Dead explains that the text is written by god Thoth himself, "so that the light might rest upon him (Osiris-NN) every day", in other words, to keep the stability of the fusion between Osiris (Body) and Re (Light). The union of Re and Osiris is in the base of the mystery of life, death and rebirth. It is the basic principle of dynamics in the cosmos. Re represents the dynamic aspect of the creation, while Osiris – his static and inert aspect. Mutual relation between the two aspects is a generator of the whole process of creation. The energy that binds this Unity and keeps its functioning is the power-Akh, or the Light (Englund, 1978, pp. 209–211).

The complex explanation of the text attached to this image supports the characteristics of the image. The figure is an amalgam of the features of the two gods. Isis and Nephtys who support the body of wrapped mummy from both sides represent the idea of symmetry, as the textual formula implies. The two goddesses are represented often as a guardians and supporters of the rising sun, so their presence here implies also the idea of the resurrection of the Sun-God and his new birth.

Using examples like this one, we can clearly see that the textual evidence linked with images could support the process of decoding the meaning of these images, which symbolically represent invisible reality or abstract concepts.

One other aspect of the system of pictorial representations in these books is striking. The first examples of the books in royal tombs are designed as if they were copied from the papyrus master-copies of the books. The images of the gods and demons are drawn only schematically as a supplement to the sacred texts. Later, after few generations, these images are represented as the typical images of the Egyptian pictorial system – they received new form and color, with many artistic details. The image of the king also penetrates the world of the representations in the sacred books. The king was represented traveling in the solar bark, surrounded by the gods etc. In the earlier versions of the books, the image of the king was not part of the composition.

In the time after the New Kingdom the role of the representation in the religious texts grew to the new levels. In the Third intermediate period the practice of constructing lavishly decorated tombs come to an end. The bodies

were buried mainly in hastily cut shafts or in the older tombs. But the world of the pictorial representations found new media to express itself. The coffins and the *cartonnages* start to be decorated with religious scenes, motifs and symbols. The lack of the space leads to invention of more symbolic and decorative forms than the representations from the walls of the earlier tombs. The same development happened with the funerary papyri. Instead of the longer versions of the Book of the dead in this period appeared shorter version and compilations including royal compositions as the book of Amduat, and The Litany of Re. In these abridged versions only some of the main representations from the books play the role for the whole composition. This mixture of forms gave birth to another form of the funerary papyri – where there are no texts at all, but only highly abstract and symbolic representations. There are hundreds of symbolic scenes and motifs that replaced the sacred texts from the previous period. The power of the symbolic images discarded the sacred text written in hieroglyphs and replaced the text with the images. The images can convey metaphors and associations to a higher level that the text thus creating a new visual language of the sacred.

So, the ongoing dialog between text and image started from the fear of the representation of the invisible reality and magical power of the image and reach the level where abstract and symbolic images replaced the text, creating their own visual language. This new visual language with its ability to represent abstract or fantastic and imaginary reality in a symbolic way laid its influence also over the systems of the hieroglyphs. In the Late period and in the time of the Greek and Roman rule in Egypt, hieroglyphic system of writing become more and more complicated with the invention of the new forms of the signs, or new meanings of old signs. It gave a way to the so-called enigmatic writing that conceals the possibility of reading the sacred texts by non-initiated layman.

It could be said that ancient Egyptian culture experienced a constant shift towards the growth of importance of the visual culture instead of the written texts. It is quite extraordinary for modern readers of our own culture who paid attention to the texts more than the images following the old trend in European thinking, exemplified by the words of the pope Gregory the Great (VI c. AD.) who said that the images are the only books for the illiterate.

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